Artificial Intelligence in Diplomacy: Opportunities, Challenges, and the Future Directions for International Relations

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Abstract

Artificial intelligence (AI) is changing how states and international organizations conduct diplomacy, from treaty analysis to crisis forecasting and public engagement. This paper looks at the opportunities AI creates for diplomatic practice — policy analysis, predictive analytics, crisis management, machine translation, public diplomacy, and decision support — alongside the risks it introduces, including algorithmic bias, privacy erosion, cybersecurity vulnerabilities, deepfake-driven misinformation, and unresolved questions of human oversight. Drawing on developments between 2023 and 2026, it compares how the United Nations, the United States, the European Union, and China have approached AI governance and diplomatic application, and finds distinct institutional philosophies rather than technical consensus. The paper then considers what a more AI-integrated system of international relations might look like, and applies these lessons to a smaller state, Jordan, whose foreign ministry faces many of the same opportunities on a tighter budget and with fewer AI-ready staff. It argues that AI's diplomatic value depends less on the sophistication of the technology itself than on the institutional capacity of states and organizations to govern it responsibly, and that the growing digital divide between AI-capable and AI-dependent states may prove as consequential as the technology itself.

Introduction

In August 2024, State Department employees sent the U.S. government's new AI assistant more than ten thousand prompts in a single day. They were not testing a novelty. They were drafting cables, summarizing reports, and translating documents — the unglamorous paperwork that occupies most of a diplomat's actual working day (U.S. Department of State, 2023, 2024). That detail says something about where diplomacy is headed: the work most likely to be automated is not the dramatic part outsiders imagine, the late-night treaty session or the tense phone call between rival capitals, but the constant, high-volume information processing that makes those moments possible in the first place.

Artificial intelligence refers to computational systems capable of performing tasks that ordinarily require human reasoning, such as interpreting language, recognizing patterns, or forecasting outcomes. Diplomacy is the practice through which states and international actors manage relationships, negotiate interests, and resolve disputes without resort to force. Foreign ministries increasingly use machine learning to sift through diplomatic cables, generative AI to draft communications, and predictive models to anticipate instability before it becomes conflict (Bjola, 2020). Large language models becoming widely accessible in the early 2020s lowered the technical barrier, and ministries that once treated AI as a research curiosity now experiment with it as a working tool (Bjola & Manor, 2024a, 2024b).

AI has also become an object of diplomacy in its own right, not just an instrument of it. Governments now negotiate rules for its development, data flows, and military use through bodies such as the United Nations, the OECD, and NATO, turning AI governance itself into a live diplomatic issue. This paper reviews the opportunities and risks the technology presents, compares how four major actors have responded, and considers what a more AI-integrated system of international relations might look like, including what that might mean specifically for Jordan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

Opportunities of AI in Diplomacy

AI's clearest diplomatic value so far lies in processing information at a scale no human staff could match. Foreign ministries generate enormous volumes of cables, treaties, and intelligence reports, and machine learning tools can now summarize, cross-reference, and flag inconsistencies far faster than manual review allows. StateChat, introduced above, is the clearest example of this in practice: within its first day of full deployment it was already supporting drafting, summarization, and translation work across the Department's missions (U.S. Department of State, 2023, 2024). But summarization is only the entry point. AI increasingly supports decision-making itself, rather than replacing it. Bjola (2020) identifies several roles it can play here — an assistant handling routine drafting, a critic offering a second opinion on a policy option, or a consultant modelling the likely consequences of a choice — with effectiveness depending on how structured the decision is and how much the decision-maker trusts the system.

Predictive analytics extends this logic to conflict prevention. Long before generative AI became prominent, the U.S. Department of Defense's ICEWS programme used event-data models to anticipate rebellions and instability, achieving accuracy comparable to the Political Instability Task Force's decision-tree models (Centre for International Governance Innovation [CIGI], 2025). Contemporary systems build on this foundation, modelling conflict scenarios and tracking resource movements from open-source data. Compressing the time between an early warning sign and a policy response is often the decisive factor in crisis diplomacy.

Language remains one of diplomacy's oldest practical obstacles, and AI-driven translation is quietly dissolving it. The State Department has built translation into its daily diplomatic workflow, and Estonia's Bürokratt virtual assistant applies similar natural-language processing to deliver multilingual government services domestically — a reminder that the same underlying technology serves diplomatic and administrative functions alike (U.S. Department of State, 2023; Smidova, 2026). In public diplomacy, AI-assisted sentiment analysis lets missions gauge how foreign publics react to policy announcements in near real time; U.S. personnel in Venezuela, for instance, used generative AI sentiment analysis to better understand local reactions to American policy (U.S. Department of State, 2024). Taken together, these applications suggest AI's diplomatic value currently sits less in high-stakes negotiation than in the information management that makes negotiation possible.

Challenges and Risks

None of this comes for free. The qualities that make AI useful in diplomacy — speed, scale, pattern recognition — are largely the same qualities that make it risky. Language and predictive models are trained on historical data reflecting existing power imbalances, and a system trained mainly on material from a handful of dominant languages may systematically misread the perspectives of others, a serious liability in a field premised on understanding other actors accurately (Franke, 2021). Diplomatic communications also often involve sensitive information, and routing that material through commercial AI systems raises legitimate questions about who has access to it and where it is stored. These concerns shade into broader questions of accountability: when an AI-generated forecast contributes to a flawed decision, responsibility cannot transfer to the machine, yet diffused authorship can obscure where human judgment should have intervened.

Cybersecurity compounds these risks. Foreign ministries are high-value espionage targets, and AI systems that centralize sensitive information can become single points of failure if compromised. NATO's 2024 strategy update was notable for naming AI-enabled disinformation and information operations as a formal concern for the first time, alongside its traditional focus on military applications (NATO, 2024). Generative AI has made synthetic audio, video, and text convincing enough to complicate the diplomatic information environment, where the authenticity of a leaked statement can no longer be assumed. The World Economic Forum's 2025 Global Risks Report found that the adverse effects of AI are among the fastest-rising risks over a ten-year horizon (Elsner et al., 2025). Maintaining meaningful human oversight amid this pace is genuinely difficult, since AI's advantage lies in speed while diplomatic legitimacy depends on careful deliberation.

Finally, AI risks widening the gap between technologically advanced and less-resourced states. The UN's High-Level Advisory Body on AI found that 118 countries remain excluded from the major intergovernmental initiatives shaping global AI rules (United Nations, 2024), leaving many states dependent on tools built elsewhere and vulnerable to having foreign assumptions embedded in their own administrative and diplomatic processes. This is not an abstract concern for a country like Jordan, a point taken up in more detail later in this paper.

Case Studies

These risks and opportunities play out differently depending on who is doing the governing. Four cases illustrate the range.

The United Nations has positioned itself as the natural forum for AI governance diplomacy. Its High-Level Advisory Body on AI, convened in October 2023, published its final report, *Governing AI for Humanity*, in September 2024 after consulting more than two thousand participants worldwide (United Nations, 2024). Rather than proposing a binding international AI agency, the report recommended lighter mechanisms: an AI Office within the Secretariat, an independent scientific panel, and a Global Dialogue on AI Governance. These recommendations fed into the Global Digital Compact, adopted at the Summit of the Future in September 2024, giving the UN's approach a degree of intergovernmental backing that most other AI governance efforts lack.

The United States has approached AI mainly as a tool for modernizing statecraft rather than as a subject for new binding law. The State Department's Enterprise Artificial Intelligence Strategy, released in November 2023, set department-wide goals for secure infrastructure, responsible use, and cultural adoption of AI (U.S. Department of State, 2023). Its most visible product, StateChat, deployed in August 2024, supports the Department's workforce directly, while the Partnership for Global Inclusivity on AI, launched with major technology firms in September 2024, extended this approach into development diplomacy abroad (U.S. Department of State, 2023).

The European Union has instead treated AI governance itself as an instrument of external policy. Its Artificial Intelligence Act, which entered into force in August 2024, became the world's first comprehensive horizontal AI regulation, and Brussels has actively promoted it as a reference point for jurisdictions designing their own frameworks (European Commission, 2024). Analysts describe this as a form of AI diplomacy, in which regulatory standard-setting becomes a source of geopolitical influence for the EU (Franke, 2021).

China has pursued a parallel but distinct strategy centred on capacity-building rather than regulatory export. Xi Jinping's Global AI Governance Initiative, announced at the Belt and Road Forum in October 2023, frames cooperation around sovereignty, development, and non-interference, appealing to Global South governments wary of Western-defined rules (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, 2023). This has since expanded into a broader action plan and proposals for a World AI Cooperation Organization, delivered alongside continued exports of AI infrastructure through the Digital Silk Road (World Economic Forum, 2025).

Table 1 summarizes these four approaches side by side.

Table 1
AI Strategies of Major Diplomatic Actors

Actor	AI Strategy	Diplomatic Focus	Strengths	Challenges
United Nations	Soft governance via High-Level Advisory Body; Global Digital Compact	Build consensus on global AI governance norms	Broad legitimacy; inclusive, global consultation	No binding enforcement; slow, consensus-based process
United States	Enterprise adoption (StateChat); light-touch domestic regulation	Modernize statecraft; export AI partnerships abroad	Fast deployment; strong technical and commercial base	Fragmented regulation; data-sovereignty concerns abroad
European Union	Binding horizontal regulation (the AI Act)	Export regulatory standards as a source of influence	First-mover regulatory leadership; rights-based credibility	Lags the U.S. and China in raw capability; compliance burden
China	State-directed capacity-building; infrastructure export (Digital Silk Road)	Sovereignty-centred cooperation with Global South states	Appeals to states wary of Western-defined rules; infrastructure investment	Limited transparency; seen as serving state interests

The Future of AI in International Relations

None of these four approaches has become dominant, and the table above probably understates how much they still borrow from one another in practice. What happens next depends less on which philosophy wins than on whether they can be made to work together.

Fully autonomous diplomacy, in which AI systems negotiate without human intervention, remains distant and may not be desirable even where technically feasible — diplomatic legitimacy depends on a recognizable human actor being accountable for what is said. More plausible is the spread of agentic AI within government generally: a coalition including Estonia, Ukraine, the United States, and the World Bank has begun outlining how AI agents capable of independent, multi-step action might be embedded across government functions, from policy drafting to public service delivery (Tucker, 2025). Estonian officials have framed this shift in security terms, arguing that societies able to integrate AI into government fastest will hold a practical advantage over slower-moving rivals (Tucker, 2025).

On governance, the coming years will likely be defined by competition between several regulatory philosophies: the EU's binding, rights-based model; the U.S. preference for light-touch, innovation-first governance; China's sovereignty-centred, capacity-building approach; and lighter frameworks such as Singapore's Model AI Governance Framework for Generative AI, which relies on voluntary, sector-specific guidance developed jointly with industry (Infocomm Media Development Authority of Singapore & AI Verify Foundation, 2024). The OECD's updated AI Principles, now endorsed by forty-seven jurisdictions, and NATO's Principles of Responsible Use offer partial convergence around transparency and accountability, but a single binding international treaty remains unlikely given how divergent these interests are (OECD, 2024; NATO, 2024). The more realistic path is incremental interoperability between frameworks, paired with continued human-AI collaboration in which diplomats retain final judgment over what AI systems recommend. These four cases set the terms other states operate within; smaller and middle-income states, Jordan among them, adopt AI under very different constraints.

Implications for Jordan

Jordan already has a governance framework to build on. The Ministry of Digital Economy and Entrepreneurship launched the National AI Strategy and Implementation Plan (2023–2027) in November 2022, built around five pillars — capacity-building, research, investment, regulation, and public-sector application — and backed by 68 planned government projects (Ministry of Digital Economy and Entrepreneurship, 2022). That gives the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Expatriates something to plug into rather than a governance question to answer alone.

The clearest opportunity is consular services. Much of the Ministry's daily workload involves routine requests from expatriates and travelers — passport renewals, document attestation, visa inquiries — the kind of high-volume, low-ambiguity task AI already handles well elsewhere. A chatbot-based triage system, modelled loosely on StateChat but scaled to Jordan's needs, could handle first-line queries and free staff for cases that genuinely require judgment.

Translation is a second area, though a harder one. AI tools trained mainly on Modern Standard Arabic often perform poorly on Jordanian and broader Levantine dialects, since Arabic's diglossia — the gap between the formal written language and the spoken vernacular — is a well-documented obstacle for machine translation (Habash, 2010). Off-the-shelf tools are more reliable for formal correspondence than for the colloquial Arabic used in everyday consular interactions, so the Ministry would need dialect-adapted tools rather than assuming general-purpose software will simply work.

Crisis response is where the stakes are highest. Jordan's 2023 evacuation of Jordanian and other nationals from Sudan, coordinated through a joint national crisis cell, showed the Ministry can move quickly under pressure (Jordan Times, 2023). AI tools that fuse open-source flight, security, and social-media data could give a future crisis cell earlier warning, but only as an input to decisions officials continue to make themselves.

Digital and public diplomacy round out the picture. Jordan's eleven-place rise in the UN's 2024 E-Government Development Index reflects real momentum, driven partly by the expansion of the Sanad digital services application (Jordan News Agency [Petra], 2024), and AI-assisted sentiment analysis could extend that momentum into how missions abroad track public reaction to Jordanian policy. The challenge throughout is capacity: Jordan has fewer AI-ready staff and a smaller budget than the ministries profiled above, so success will depend less on the most advanced tools than on adopting a smaller number of them carefully.

A Personal Reflection

Writing this paper as a computer science student, I kept noticing how much of what makes AI useful in diplomacy — speed, consistency, the ability to process huge amounts of text — is also what makes it a poor substitute for a human diplomat. A model can flag an inconsistency in a cable or draft a first pass at a translation, but it cannot read a room, sense when a counterpart is bluffing, or judge that a technically accurate statement would be diplomatically unwise to send. Those calls rest on trust, cultural fluency, and accountability, none of which a system trained on past text can fully reproduce, no matter how well it performs on a benchmark.

This is why I think AI belongs in a supporting role in diplomacy, not an operational one. The risks covered in this paper — bias, opacity, the temptation to let a fast tool make a decision that deserves slower thought — are not really technical problems that better engineering will eventually solve. They are governance problems, and they call for the kind of institutional discipline that has little to do with model size or training data. A foreign ministry that adopts AI without first deciding who is accountable when it gets something wrong is solving the easy problem and skipping the hard one.

Conclusion

AI has already changed how diplomacy is practiced, even where it has not changed what diplomacy fundamentally is. Foreign ministries use it to manage information, anticipate crises, and communicate across languages, while increasingly treating its governance as a diplomatic subject in its own right. Comparing the UN, the United States, the EU, and China shows that no single approach to AI diplomacy has become dominant; each reflects distinct institutional priorities rather than shared technical consensus, and Jordan's own experience suggests that smaller states will keep having to borrow selectively from all four rather than copy any one model outright.

Three recommendations follow. Foreign ministries, Jordan's included, should invest in AI literacy among diplomatic staff rather than delegating the technology entirely to IT departments. Multilateral institutions should prioritize interoperability between regulatory frameworks over pursuit of a single binding treaty in the short term. And donor states should treat AI capacity-building for underrepresented countries as a matter of diplomatic stability, not only development policy, given how closely the digital divide now tracks influence over AI's future rules.

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